A SUMMARY OF THE ENTIRE HILCHOT SHABBAT IN 14 CLASSES

Trapping, Killing, Sewing and Tearing

Class 10 of 14

Series: Laws of Shabbat — a 14-part course

Shiur: 10 of 14

Topic: Tzad (Trapping), Shochet (Killing), Tofer and Kore'a (Sewing and Tearing)

Recorded: Tiferet Eyal, Hendon — 5 February 2019

Dedication: For the refuah shelemah of a member of the community, as announced in the recording.

Schedule note: The course is a week behind; the final Q&A session will be used to complete the material. Remaining shiurim: 26 Feb, 5 Mar, 12 Mar, 26 Mar.

Recap

Last time: tying and untying, cleaning clothes, and (the week before) dyeing. Tonight: trapping, killing, and sewing/tearing.

Part A — Tzad (Trapping)

Background and two key principles

The Mishkan's coverings included rams' skins and the skins of the *tachash* (now extinct) — animals that had to be trapped.

1. **The kind of creature:** creatures **commonly trapped** for use (deer, birds such as parrots, fish, dogs) — trapping them is a **Torah** prohibition. Creatures trapped only to be rid of them (mice, rats, flies, mosquitoes) — only **rabbinic**.
2. **The enclosure:** it is Torah-level only if the creature is confined where you can take hold of it **easily, in a single lunge**. A bird in a cage — trapped; a bird brought into a living room — only rabbinic (you would still have to chase it). A deer in a living room — easily caught in a moment or two, so trapped.

Mousetraps

- Best: set the trap **before Shabbat** — it may catch mice on Shabbat.
- Setting it on Shabbat right in front of a mouse that goes straight in — **Torah** prohibition.
- Setting it where a mouse *may* enter later — only **rabbinic**.
- Since mice aren't trapped for use (rabbinic) and the trapping isn't immediate (rabbinic), it is twice removed — and with real discomfort (including emotional distress at mice in the house), Chacham Ovadia permits **setting the trap yourself**, not just via a non-Jew.

- **Rats**, especially with children around, are dangerous — certainly permitted.
- Poison traps set before Shabbat are fine.

Closing a window on a butterfly

A butterfly flew in; it turns cold and you want to shut the window. Trapping it is a *pesik reisha* — but in a room it is only rabbinic (too big to catch in one go), and you are acting because of **discomfort**, not to trap it. **Pesik reisha bidrabanan bimkom tza'ar** — permitted.

Pets and domesticated animals

- A domesticated animal that accepts its owner's authority is already considered "trapped" — anyone may confine it. (Animals are generally **muktseh** — don't lift them; you may nudge them along, gently — see the Muktseh shiur.)
- A **parrot** or a newly bought **dog** that doesn't yet submit to its owner is not domesticated: if you open the cage, closing it re-traps it. Feed through the bars, or block the opening with your body. Leaving the house past such a dog: don't open the door wide and close it; slip out with your body blocking the gap.

Trapping a person?

A seriously discussed question — locking a child in a room, or a Jewish prison guard in Israel recapturing an escapee on Shabbat:

- The **Tzitz Eliezer** (Rav Eliezer Waldenberg): young children are under their parents' authority — like domesticated.
- Humans aren't creatures "commonly trapped", so at most rabbinic. (A dangerous criminal is a different matter entirely.)
- Deeper: whenever the Torah says "take" a person (*kach et Aharon*...), **Rashi** comments **קָחֵהוּ בִּדְבָרִים** — *take him with words*. The **Maharal** explains: a person's essence is his mind. You can confine his body, but a prisoner in London can be thinking of Australia — his mind is free. So some argue there is no "trapping" of human beings at all.

Wasps and mosquitoes

Trapping them is only rabbinic. If one is **on your skin or about to sting**, Chazal waived the prohibition — you may **trap** it (e.g. under a cup). If it is just buzzing around the room, no. **Killing** it is not permitted — unless there is danger (an allergy; arguably near a baby).

Part B — Shochet (Killing)

In the Mishkan the trapped animals were slaughtered for their hides. Killing any creature is forbidden.

Fly spray

Spraying **directly at** insects — forbidden. Spraying **around the room with the window open** — permitted: they have an escape route, so their death is not inevitable. ("The aim of philosophy," said Wittgenstein, "is to show the fly the way out of the fly-bottle.") Spraying a sealed room — forbidden.

Insects in the toilet or the sink

Flushing a toilet with insects in it — permitted by the poskim, for several reasons:

1. **Melacha she'einah tzrichah legufah** — you aren't killing them to use them (only rabbinic).
2. Death isn't immediate — they may drown later in the pipes, so it is indirect.
3. **Kavod habriyot** — human dignity overrides rabbinic prohibitions.

A sink with spiders: no human-dignity factor here, but if the tap water lands beside them (not directly on them) and they are carried off later, it is indirect and permitted. Don't aim at them, and don't fill the basin until they inevitably drown.

Checking vegetables for insects

Ideally check before Shabbat (mint, lettuce). On Shabbat:

- If it is **not certain** there are insects — permitted: a **safek pesik reisha** (doubtful inevitability).
- If it is **visibly infested** — forbidden; washing will inevitably kill them.
- Produce that is **almost always infested** (e.g. raspberries) — practically cannot be checked on Shabbat.

Drawing blood

Blood is the life-force (**כִּי הַדָּם הוּא הַנָּפֶשׁ**), so drawing blood **for use** is a Torah prohibition:

- A **blood test** that can wait a few days — forbidden on Shabbat.
- **Pinching** hard enough to bring blood to the surface — forbidden, even with permission.

Brushing teeth

- **Without toothpaste:** squeezing water from the bristles is not an issue. Bleeding gums: if you **don't usually** bleed, it isn't inevitable — permitted. If you **almost always** bleed, it is a pesik reisha — don't brush on Shabbat.
- No special Shabbat toothbrush needed; you may rinse the brush afterwards (it's for cleanliness, not preparing for the next day).
- **Toothpaste:** most poskim forbid it — **memare'ach** (smoothing). **Chacham Ovadia permits** it: smoothing is forbidden only when you want the smooth result (e.g. sealing a barrel with wax), not toothpaste that is immediately rinsed away. Prefer **mouthwash or liquid toothpaste**; if genuinely stuck and uncomfortable, there is what to rely on.
- **Floss** — the same as brushing: only if you don't usually bleed.

Part C — Tofer and Kore'a (Sewing and Tearing)

The Mishkan's cloth panels were sewn together. **Tofer** = joining two items together — sewing, **gluing** paper, **sellotaping**, **stapling**. **Kore'a** = separating them. Pulling a loose stitch tight to close a gap in a tablecloth or shirt is re-sewing — forbidden.

Buttons, safety pins, zips, Velcro

- **Buttons** — designed to open and close, so not sewing (like closing a door isn't building).
- **Safety pins** — likewise permitted, even for an extended period.

- **Zips** — permitted, e.g. zipping a hood onto a coat, even if left on for weeks.
- **Velcro** — more debated: avoid fastening it on Shabbat for more than seven days (e.g. new Velcro shoes fastened once and then slipped on and off).
- New **socks joined** by the manufacturer — may be cut apart with a knife; the join was never meant to be permanent.

Opening post

- Business correspondence — muktseh; don't open it.
- Personal, non-business letters — may be opened by **tearing the envelope destructively** (not making a neat "receptacle"). Unsealing the flap neatly is hard to justify (the Ra'avad and others debate it).

Toilet paper

Tearing toilet paper along its perforation is **mechatech** (cutting to size). Pre-tear it before Shabbat. If you forgot: ask a non-Jew; if none is available, tear it with a **shinui** (e.g. between the elbows, or with the weaker hand) — permitted because of **kavod habriyot**. Don't deliberately aim for the perforation; if it happens to tear there, fine.

Food packaging and bottles — to be discussed.

Summary

- **Tzad:** Torah-level only for commonly-trapped creatures in a confined space. Mousetraps — before Shabbat, or on Shabbat if not trapping immediately. Closing a window on a butterfly is fine; domesticated pets may be confined; wasps on you may be trapped but not killed.
- **Shochet:** fly spray around an open-windowed room; flushing toilets fine; tap water beside, not on, insects; check vegetables only if not definitely infested; no drawing blood. Brushing teeth without toothpaste is fine (unless you usually bleed); toothpaste per Chacham Ovadia, but prefer mouthwash or liquid toothpaste.
- **Tofer/Kore'a:** no gluing, taping, stapling or tightening stitches. Buttons, safety pins and zips fine; avoid long-term Velcro. Tear personal envelopes open destructively; pre-tear toilet paper.

Coming Up

Shiur 11 — 26 February: Writing and building — cutting through cakes with writing on them, puzzles, CCTV, Lego, opening cans and bottles, umbrellas — and swimming on Shabbat.

B'Ezrat Hashem

Watch or listen to this shiur: youtu.be/X4srKyFukW0 · More shiurim: rabbikada.com